



Seasonal fun

LIFE IN THE ALPS is exceptionally healthy. The water is clean, the air is clear, and the steep slopes and out-of-doors life provide ample exercise. Although many tourists visit the Alps to experience these benefits, local people too live in every peak and valley. Each group has its own history, customs, and even language.



A ROMANTIC SLEIGH RIDE

On a Sunday in January or February, young people in the Engadine traditionally participate in the *Schlitteda*, a procession of horse-drawn sleighs. It is a picturesque event, as the sleighs are beautifully decorated and their riders dressed in old-fashioned costumes. After the ride there is a celebratory ball. The *Schlitteda* was originally held in order to provide an opportunity for young men and women to meet and fall in love, though nowadays married people participate too.

A winter wonderland

Though for the most part Swiss-German is spoken in the Engadine area of the Swiss Alps, which is very popular with tourists, some 70,000 people here speak *Romansh*, the fourth-largest language in Switzerland. Actually, *Romansh* consists of a number of distinct but related dialects. Just as the language persists, so do some of the traditional customs, such as the *Schlitteda* and the *Chalandamarz* (see below.)



The "herdsman" who heads the procession also leads the singing.

CHALANDAMARZ

On the first of March, local boys carrying cow bells form a procession. The boy with the biggest bell leads. He represents a herdsman and those behind him are his "calves." Their job is to make as much noise as possible so as to drive winter away.

